

C1.3.1.2 Detecting Tone and Subtext in Social Interactions — Practice

Part 1: Fill in the Blank

Complete each exchange with the most natural sarcasm marker or interjection from the word bank. Use each word/phrase once.

Word bank: obvio · ya, seguro · no está mal · cómo no · no me digas · qué bueno

1. —Perdí mi vuelo y encima me robaron la maleta. —¡_____!
2. —¿Te gustó el regalo que te di? —_____. (mild, hedged — not enthusiastic)
3. —¿Tú crees que el jefe va a subirnos el sueldo este año? —_____.
4. —Otra vez llegó tarde a la reunión. —_____. (sarcastic, implying "of course he did, no surprise")
5. —Dice que esta vez sí va a hacer ejercicio todos los días. —_____. (implying "we've heard that before")

Part 2: Sincere or Sarcastic?

Read each short exchange. Based on the context given, decide whether the second speaker's line is **sincere** or **sarcastic**, and briefly explain the clue that tells you.

1. Context: Marta just found out she got the job she interviewed for last week. —Marta, ¡me dieron el trabajo! —
¡Qué bueno, felicidades!
Sincere or sarcastic? _____ Clue: _____
2. Context: Diego borrowed his friend's laptop and returned it with a cracked screen, with no apology. —Diego, me devolviste la laptop rota. —Sí, qué bueno que te diste cuenta.
Sincere or sarcastic? _____ Clue: _____
3. Context: A coworker asks Ana what she thought of a presentation that was disorganized and ran twenty minutes over. —¿Qué te pareció la presentación? —No estuvo mal, pero podría ser más clara.
Sincere or sarcastic (i.e., genuinely mild vs. softened criticism)? _____ Clue: _____
4. Context: Two friends are reminiscing about a trip where everything went right. —Fue un viaje increíble, todo salió perfecto. —Qué bueno, me alegro mucho.
Sincere or sarcastic? _____ Clue: _____
5. Context: Pablo asks his sister if she remembered to buy milk, after she forgot the last three times. —¿Te acordaste de comprar la leche? —Obvio que sí... como siempre.
Sincere or sarcastic? _____ Clue: _____

Part 3: Translation (English to Spanish)

Translate the following into Spanish, choosing wording that captures the intended tone (sincere or sarcastic) described in parentheses.

1. "Oh, great." (sarcastic, after hearing bad news)
2. "Of course, how considerate." (sarcastic, about someone who did something thoughtless)
3. "It's not bad." (hedged criticism — the speaker actually didn't like it much)
4. "You don't say." (sarcastic — implying the news wasn't surprising at all)
5. "Sure, right." (sarcastic disbelief that something will happen)

Part 4: Sentence Construction

Build a full sentence or short exchange in Spanish using the given cue and intended tone. Include enough context in your sentence that the tone is clear even in writing (e.g., a setup line, an ellipsis, or a follow-up remark).

1. Cue: *ya* — sarcastic disbelief that a friend will actually show up on time.
2. Cue: *no me digas* — sincere surprise at unexpected news.
3. Cue: *cómo no* — sincere, genuine willingness to help.
4. Cue: hedged criticism about a meal that was actually disappointing.
5. Cue: *claro que sí* — sarcastic, implying doubt rather than agreement.

Answer Key

Part 1

1. ¡No me digas! (or ¡Qué bueno!, sarcastic) — either reads naturally; the model answer uses *no me digas* for sarcastic disbelief at the bad luck.
2. No está mal.
3. Ya, seguro.
4. Cómo no.
5. No me digas.

Part 2

1. Sincere. Clue: the context is genuinely good news (Marta got the job) and there's nothing in the exchange suggesting flat or ironic delivery — *qué bueno* here is plain congratulations.
2. Sarcastic. Clue: the situation (a broken laptop, no apology) is bad, so *qué bueno* flips to meaning the opposite — the speaker is annoyed, not pleased.
3. Softened/hedged criticism, not sincere mild praise. Clue: the presentation was disorganized and ran over time, so "no estuvo mal, pero podría ser más clara" is Ana being diplomatic about a presentation she didn't think was good.
4. Sincere. Clue: the trip genuinely went well, and the response matches the good news with no contextual mismatch.
5. Sarcastic. Clue: "como siempre" ("as always") is a giveaway — it points out this is a repeated failure, so *obvio que sí* is not confident sincerity but exasperated irony.

Part 3

1. Qué bueno...
2. Cómo no, qué considerado.
3. No está mal.
4. No me digas.
5. Ya, seguro.

Part 4 (sample answers — wording will vary)

1. —¿Crees que Marco llegue a tiempo hoy? —Ya, seguro, como todas las veces.
2. —Adivina qué, me aceptaron en la universidad. —¡No me digas! ¡Qué emoción!
3. —¿Me puedes ayudar a mudarme el sábado? —Cómo no, ahí estaré.
4. —¿Qué tal la cena? —No estuvo mal, aunque esperaba algo un poco más sazonado.
5. —¿Vas a llegar temprano mañana? —Claro que sí... (dicho sin ninguna confianza en la voz)